



University Centre Abdelhafid Boussouf E-learning Centre



English – Level 2

– Lesson 02 – Forms and Functions of Clauses

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Science and Technology	• Mathematics and Computer Science • Technical Science	Licentiate 2	-MI -ST
Economic Science	• Economic Science • Commercial Science • Management Science	Licentiate 2	All specialties

Objectives of the Lesson

- To learn more about clauses and their forms.
- To enable you to understand the functions of clauses.

Forms of Clauses

Essentially, there are three (03) main forms of clauses: a **noun clause**, an **adjective clause**, and an **adverb clause**. Each one has its own distinctive functions.

1. Noun Clause: is a subordinate clause that includes a **subordinating conjunction** (what, where, why, how, where, when, who, whom, which, whose, whether, that, if.) followed by a **clause**. It takes the place of the noun in the sentence and performs its grammatical function*. Within noun clauses **No commas** are needed.

Examples:

Adam forgot that it was his mother's birthday.

Subordinating conjunction

Clause

I cannot recall where I put my glasses.

Subordinating conjunction

Clause

2. Adjective Clause: (also referred to as relative clause) is a subordinate clause formed by a **subordinating conjunction** followed by a **clause**. It is a group of words that provides a description of the noun in a sentence instead of a one word adjective*.

The **subordinators** that present adjective clauses (also called relative pronouns) are: **who, whom, which, whose, that, where, when**.

Example:

Last summer we visited Tassili, which is famous for its caves.

Noun

Sub. Conj

Adjective Clause

3. Adverb Clause: is a subordinate clause formed by a **subordinating conjunction** (such as: **after, although, unless, until, when...**) followed by a **clause**. It is a group of words that provides a description of the verb in a sentence instead of a one word adverb*.

Example:

I have been saving money so that I can buy my own laptop.

Sub. Conj

Adverb Clause

*Sub. Conj= Subordinating Conjunction.

Functions of Clauses

1. Noun clauses have **nominal functions**. It is possible for a noun clause to act as: a **subject**, an **object**, and as a **complement**. It can also come in patterns such as: **after a preposition**, and **after an adjective**.

➡ **As a Subject**, for example: Whoever took my notebook should give it back to me.
 Noun clause (Functioning as a subject)

In this example the sentence is about “whoever took my notebook”, and whoever took the notebook is the person responsible for the action of giving it back, thus the noun clause “Whoever took my notebook” is the subject of the sentence.

➡ **As an Object**, such as: My friend will believe whatever I tell her.
 Noun clause (Functioning as an object)

In this example the noun clause “whatever I tell her” is governed by the verb “believe”, thus it is the ‘object’ simply because it answers the question believe what?

Note: Objects are words that receive another part of a sentence. Generally, an object is governed by a verb.

➡ **As a Complement**, as in: My philosophy is that everyone deserves a second chance.
 Noun clause (functioning as a complement)

In this example the noun clause “that everyone deserves a second chance” is a complement because it provides more information about “philosophy”.

Note: A complement is crucial to complete the meaning of a sentence, by providing information about the noun. It follows a linking verb (such as: is, are, my, will, was...).

➡ **After a preposition**, for example: I do not approve of what the minister said earlier.
 Preposition Sub. Conj Clause

➡ **After an adjective**, as in: It is strange that there are no lights on.
 Adjective Sub. Conj Clause

2. Adjective clauses function as **adjectives**. An adjective clause does precisely the same job as that performed by a single word adjective in a sentence. **Restrictive adjective clauses** do not require **commas**, but with **nonessential (nonrestrictive) adjective clauses** commas are always necessary.

➡ **Restrictive Adjective Clause** is essential to understand **unspecified subject**, and therefore completes the meaning of the sentence. It cannot be omitted, or offset by commas. It is also known by the label **defining clause**.

Example:

The man **who** robbed the bank is in jail.

Sub. Conjunction Restrictive Adjective Clause

➡ **Non-Restrictive Adjective Clause** provides additional information about a **specified subject**. The sentence still makes complete sense without it. **Nonessential** clause requires commas. It is also known by the label **non-defining clause**.

Example:

My classmate, **who** lives downtown, said he would go on an African safari.

Nonrestrictive Adjective Clause

The sentence is grammatically correct without the Nonrestrictive Adjective Clause: My classmate said he would go on an African safari.

3. Adverb clauses function as an **adverbial clause**. An **adverbial clause** is a group of words that describes an entire clause by providing additional information relating to^{*}: **time** (when, before, after, until, since, as soon as), **place** (where, wherever), **cause** (because, as, since), **purpose** (so that, in order that), **result** (so ... that, such ... that), **condition** (if, unless, as long as) and **concession** (although, even though).

Examples:

As soon as the thief heard the police sirens, he ran away.

Sub. Conj Adverbial Clause of Time

Although he has a terrible voice, he loves singing.

Sub. Conj Adverbial Clause of Concession

Practice

Identify the form and function of clauses in the following sentences

1. The classroom where we study is not very clean.
2. It is unlike you to miss the 08:00 a.m. school bus.
3. I have a lot of books most of which I have not read.
4. Mrs. Green still believes that ghosts exist.
5. Jaden seemed undecided whether to go out or stay indoors.

References

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